Missing Teen Found Alive After Six Days in Australian Woods

From: CBC World Mined: 2026-11-12 5 min read

A teenager lost in the Australian woods for six days is safe at home.

William, 17, was found alive on Thursday beside a creek near Walhalla, a former gold-mining town about 185 kilometres east of Melbourne. He had gone camping with a teenage friend last Friday and disappeared after walking a short distance from the campsite to pick up more gear. A police helicopter crew spotted him asleep on a flat rock by the creek, surrounded by **wilderness**. He woke to the sound of the helicopter, gave the crew a thumbs up, and was **winched** up to safety.

Video from the helicopter showed him shirtless and **sunburned**, wearing shorts and boots and using towels as blankets. Police said he was in good spirits and mostly in good health, and he was later taken to a hospital so doctors could keep an eye on him. His mother, Elizabeth, was **overjoyed**. "I'm just over the moon that he's alive," she told reporters, joking that he was grounded for life.

William has Level 2 **autism**, which means he needs substantial support, according to the Australian advocacy group Autism360. People with this level of support may find changes to routines hard and may struggle with social communication. After he became lost, William walked for days up and down "some very steep **terrain**," Acting Police Inspector Jason Benbow said. He spent his last two days at the creek, stuck there by the steep ground about 2 kilometres from his campsite.

The spring weather had been mild, with little rain, which helped. More than 100 emergency workers and volunteers had joined the search. In the end, it was the helicopter crew, and a thumbs up from a boy on a rock, that brought him home.

Word Treasure

winched -- To be winched up means to be lifted by a cable from a helicopter.

wilderness -- Wilderness is wild land far from towns, with no roads or houses.

terrain -- Terrain is the shape and surface of a piece of land.

autism -- Autism is a way the brain works that can change how a person talks, learns, and handles change.

sunburned -- Sunburned skin is red and sore after spending too long in strong sun.

overjoyed -- Overjoyed means extremely happy.

Background you need

When someone goes missing in wild country, police and volunteers search the area on foot and from the air, because thick bush and steep hills make it easy to get lost and hard to find someone.

Helicopters help because their crews can look down over large areas and lift a person out with a cable when the ground is too steep to walk.

Autism is a different way the brain works, and some autistic people need a lot of everyday support, for example with changes to plans or with talking to other people.

Camping trips in the bush need care, because weather, rough ground and distance from towns can turn a short walk into a dangerous situation.

Break it down

LEAD: A teenager lost for six days in the Australian woods is safe at home.
KEY EVENT: William, 17, is found alive beside a creek near Walhalla.
+- WHO: William, his mother Elizabeth, and Acting Police Inspector Jason Benbow
+- WHEN: He went missing last Friday and was found on Thursday
+- WHERE: Beside a creek about 2 kilometres from his campsite, near Walhalla, about 185 kilometres east of Melbourne
EVIDENCE: A helicopter crew spotted him asleep on a flat rock, and video showed him shirtless and sunburned.
CONTEXT: William has Level 2 autism and walked for days over very steep terrain.
OUTCOME: He was taken to a hospital so doctors could keep an eye on him, and more than 100 workers and volunteers had joined the search.

Why it matters

Getting lost in wild country can happen to anyone, so knowing how search teams work and why staying near water can help matters. The story also shows how support needs shape what a person can do when plans suddenly change.

Test what you remember

1. How long was William lost in the woods?

- (A) Two days
- (B) Four days
- (C) Six days
- (D) Ten days

2. Where was William found?

- (A) On a road near Walhalla
- (B) At a hospital in Melbourne
- (C) Asleep on a flat rock beside a creek
- (D) In a cave near the campsite

3. How did the helicopter crew lift William to safety?

- (A) They winched him up
- (B) They carried him down a path
- (C) They waited for him to walk out
- (D) They sent a dog to guide him

4. What does Level 2 autism mean, according to the article?

- (A) William cannot speak at all
- (B) William needs substantial support
- (C) William needs no help at all
- (D) William is afraid of helicopters

5. Why did William spend his last two days at the creek?

- (A) He wanted to go fishing
- (B) His friend told him to wait there
- (C) The creek was the way home
- (D) The steep ground kept him stuck there

6. What helped William survive the six days?

- (A) Mild spring weather with little rain
- (B) A phone that still worked
- (C) A rescue team that stayed with him
- (D) Snow that kept him cool

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: C 2: C 3: A 4: B 5: D 6: A

Questions to think about

1. Police: Police said William was in good spirits and mostly in good health, and took him to a hospital so doctors could keep an eye on him.

2. William's mother, Elizabeth: Elizabeth was overjoyed that her son was alive and joked that he was grounded for life.

3. Autism360: The advocacy group explains that Level 2 autism means a person needs substantial support.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):